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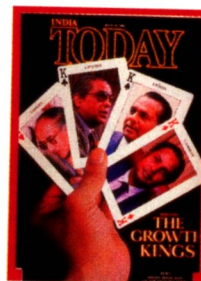
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Back in 1982, in INDIA TODAY's cover story "The Growth Kings", the pride of place was given to self-made entrepreneur Dhirubhai Ambani and his Rs 300-crore Reliance Textile Industries. In that story, rival industrialists had predicted: "The Ambani bubble will burst." Our cover story had quite presciently said, "He combines a very Indian understanding of money and trading with a very modern understanding of industry, marketing and technology." Exactly 25 years later, the late Dhirubhai's eldest son Mukesh Ambani is within a few Sensex points of becoming the world's richest man if market capitalisation be the measure of wealth. If one adds up his holding in flagship company, Reliance Industries Limited (RIL) and other investments, his estimated worth is already over \$60 billion. In a few weeks' time, he could surpass Bill Gates and Carlos Slim, both worth around \$63 billion. At 50, Mukesh is a veritable money machine for the country generating revenues of Rs 14 crore an hour.

He is the poster boy for India's growth story. The scale of the ambition is extraordinary. For most entrepreneurs, running one successful business is a lifetime's achievement. Mukesh is building his second massive refinery, setting up four large SEZs, planning a 1,500-town retail roll-out, and working on the biggest-ever Indian project in oil and gas exploration, all of which adds up to investments of over Rs 1,50,000 crore. The family saga has been media fodder since Dhirubhai's death in 2002 which was followed by a split with his brother in 2006.

Earlier no one had predicted that Mukesh would set the kind of turbo-charged pace he has. If Dhirubhai was a larger-than-life patriarch and younger brother Anil was the public face of Reliance, Mukesh remained an enigma, mainly because of his low-profile persona. Yet, it is the workaholic Mukesh who has led Reliance's scorching growth over the last two decades. Managing Editor Shankkar Aiyar who has been tracking Mukesh for the past 15 years and put the story together, says, "He still shuns the limelight and loathes the idea of being called the richest. He would much rather be known as the wealth creator."

Our cover story analyses the vision and the corporate philosophy that got Mukesh where he is and where he's heading. His formula has been to spot a trend, study the opportunity, think big, scale up operations, crash the costs, crush competition and move on. Added to this is his innate ability to bend the rules of the game or, when it doesn't work, change the dispensation. It is expected that by 2012 he will be worth \$100 billion. Not bad!



Our July 1982 (top) and June '85 covers



Aroon Purie
(Aroon Purie)